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VIDEO

« Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand »

BREAKING NEW GROUND

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The last Olympic cycle for Indian badminton was mainly about 'Sat-Chi' — the power-packed men's doubles duo of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty — and the dreams of an elusive gold.

At the same time, Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand or 'TreGa' were gradually learning the tricks of the trade in the demanding discipline of women's doubles.

Hyderabad's Gayatri (22), the daughter of Chief National Coach Pullela Gopichand, and Kannur's Treesa (21) were predominantly singles players on the junior circuit before the coaches decided to pair them up in 2021.

The duo has been grinding in the

shadows for the last four years — developing chemistry, chasing titles and ranking points, and tackling injuries.

With Treesa nursing a shoulder issue, the pair had to miss the Badminton Asia Championships (April 8-13) and will also skip the upcoming Sudirman Cup (April 27 - May 4).

But this time away from courts, something which elite athletes seldom get, has also provided the duo a chance to reflect on their journey so far.

In an interview at their training base — the Pullela Gopichand Badminton Academy in Hyderabad — the two shuttlers tell *Sportstar* about the learnings from missing out on Paris 2024, the battles with the

top-ranked Chinese pair, and breaking new ground.

You've been playing together since 2021. How has your partnership evolved — on and off the court?

Gayatri: Earlier, I was playing singles, but I thought doubles would be best for me. So, I paired up with Treesa, and initially, in a few tournaments, it was great to see what it was like. Then we got into the All England Open (in 2022), which we never thought would happen. We performed well (reached semifinals), and that's where we shone. Since then, it's been a great journey. We've played some good matches with the top pairs, and I got to learn a lot.

Treesa: In 2021, we started to play together. That's how I got to